

Session 28: From Old to New Humanity (Eph. 4:17-5:2)

Key Takeaways

- In Ephesians 4:22, "self" is the Greek word for "human," referring to a communal identity, not an individual one.
- The moral exhortations in chapters 4-6 are grounded in the vision of the new humanity from chapters 1-3.
- Paul doesn't tell people to become someone new. He tells people to become who they really are.

God's Family as a Renewed Humanity: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 4:17-5:2

¹⁷ Therefore I say
and I testify by the Lord,
that you should walk no longer
as the nations walk
in the futility of their mindset,
¹⁸ having been in the dark in their mindset,
estranged from the life of God
because of the ignorance which is in them,
on account of the hardness of their heart,
¹⁹ who, after making themselves calloused,
they gave themselves over
to a lack of self-control
resulting in deeds of every kind of impurity
along with insatiable desire.

²⁰ But in such a way
you did not learn the Messiah,
²¹ if indeed you have heard of him
and were taught in him,
as truth is in Jesus,
²² that y'all are to take off the old humanity
of y'all's former way of life,
which is being corrupted
by its deceptive desires,
²³ and to be renewed in the spirit of your mind,
²⁴ and to put on the new humanity
which has been created
in accordance with God,
in justice and true piety.

²⁵ Therefore, having put off the lie,
"speak truth each one with his neighbor,"
because we are members of one another.

²⁶ "Be angry and do not sin."
Do not let the sun set on your anger,
²⁷ and don't give an opportunity to the slanderer.

²⁸ The one who steals,
let him no longer steal,
²⁷ but rather let him labor,
producing good with his own hands,
so that he can have something to share with the one who has need.

²⁹ Any rotten word,
don't let it come out of y'all's mouth,
but only what is good for building up what is needed,
so that it might give grace to those who hear.

³⁰ And do not grieve the holy Spirit of God,
by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.

³¹ All bitterness and anger and wrath and blasphemy,
let it be taken from you,
along with all wickedness.

³² But be kind to one another,
compassionate,
forgiving one another,
just as God in the Messiah forgave you.

^{5:1} Therefore, become imitators of God
as beloved children,
² and walk in love,
just as the Messiah loved us
and gave himself
as an offering
and a sacrifice to God
as a pleasant aroma.

Ephesians 4:17-19

Paul picks up his portrayal of the gentile’s moral condition from [Ephesians 2:3](#) (“doing the desires of the flesh and of the mind,” Greek: *διανοια*). He stacks four phrases with overlapping and climactic meaning.

- “Futility (*ματαιος*) of the mind”
- “Darkened (*ἐσχοτιζειν*) in the mind”
- “Estranged from the life of God through ignorance”
- “Due to the hardening of the heart”

Ephesians 4:20-24

“You learned the Messiah” ([Eph. 4:20](#)) and “as truth is in Jesus” ([Eph. 4:21](#)) are unique phrases in the New Testament.

- “Learning the Messiah”: To “learn a person” is an unparalleled expression in the Bible. It assumes the content of the message and teaching of Christianity is Jesus himself, not a moral philosophy or life improvement. Being a Christian means engaging with him personally to learn a new way to be human.
- “As truth is in Jesus”: The real truth of Christian faith isn’t at its root found in a systematic arrangement of concepts. Rather, the truth is a person and is discovered by knowing and following him.

Ephesians 4:22-32

Paul contrasts the old humanity and the new humanity.

The Old Humanity	The New Humanity
Take off your old human	Put on the new human
Of your former way of life	Being renewed in the spirit of your mind
That is being ruined by deceptive desires	That has been created according to God in righteousness and holiness of truth
Take off lying	Speak truth
Anger	Not allowing the sun to set on your anger
Let the stealer no longer steal	Work so that you can share with others
The Old and New Humanity. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).	

The Old Humanity	The New Humanity
No rotten speech	Speak words that build others up and give a gift
No bitterness, anger, wrath, yelling, blasphemy	Kindness, compassion, forgiveness
<i>The Old and New Humanity. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).</i>	

Paul doesn't simply prohibit destructive behaviors. He also commends new habits and practices to replace the old. If one starts practicing generosity or conflict resolution, the experience of anger or desire for shouting matches will slowly die away.

Paul's Old Testament Quotes in 4:25-30

Ephesians 4:25 *Instructor's Translation*
 Therefore, putting off lying, speak truth each one with his neighbor.

Zechariah 8:16 *NASB**
 These are the things you are to do: speak truth to one another
**Key Words Adapted by Teacher*

The entirety of Zechariah is addressing the post-exilic community of Judah, urging them to remain faithful to the covenant in light of the divine promise.

Zechariah 8:3 *NASB*
 Thus says the LORD, "I will return to Zion and will dwell in the midst of Jerusalem. Then Jerusalem will be called the City of Truth, and the mountain of the LORD of hosts will be called the Holy Mountain."

The whole chapter calls the Israelites to live in the present in light of those future hopes, especially because of the fact that the Gentile nations will one day be summoned to build the new temple with the restored Israel (Zech. 8:20-23). The chapter fits perfectly the now-not-yet framework of Paul's worldview.

Ephesians 4:26 *Instructor's Translation*
 Be angry and do not sin.

Psalms 4:4 *Instructor's Translation*
 Shudder/Tremble (with anger) but do not sin;
 speak to your heart, but be silent.

"The psalmist advises his adversaries to keep their rage within themselves, to maintain control of their actions and their evil words. It was when they spoke out loud and acted (v. 3) that their inner evil was released to afflict the innocent. And though silence and lack of action would not remove the rot within, it would at least curtail its evil effects."

Craigie, Peter C. (2004). [*Word Biblical Commentary: Psalms 1-50*](#). Thomas Nelson Inc. 81.

"Here too Paul may have had the wider context of the psalm in mind when he used these words. He has just forbidden falsehood (4:25), one of the sins in which the psalmist's adversaries were engaged (Ps. 4:2). Paul is also about to recommend that his readers not let the sun set on their anger (4:26b), an idea that may have been prompted by the psalmist's advice to his enemies not to act on their anger, but instead to ponder their feelings in silence on their beds (Ps. 4:4b)"

Thielman, Frank S. (2007). "Ephesians." [*Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament*](#). Baker Academic. 825.

Ephesians 4:30 NIV

And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.

Isaiah 63:9b-10 NIV

^{9b} In his love and mercy he redeemed them;
he lifted them up and carried them
all the days of old.
¹⁰ Yet they rebelled
and grieved his Holy Spirit.
So he turned and became their enemy
and he himself fought against them.

"The statement echoes the language of [*Isaiah 63:10*](#), although it neither translates the Hebrew text literally ('they grieved [‘atsab] his Holy Spirit') nor matches the rendering in the LXX ('they provoked [*paroxyno*] his Holy Spirit'). Within its context, [*Isaiah 63:10*](#) describes how Israel's rebellion against God, even after he had showed them mercy, turned God into their enemy and resulted in their exile. Elsewhere in his correspondence Paul turns God's judgment on a rebellious Israel into an admonition to God's eschatologically restored people not to follow the example of their 'fathers' ([*1 Cor. 10:1-22*](#))."

Thielman, Frank S. (2007). "Ephesians." [*Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament*](#). Baker Academic. 825-826.

Ephesians 5:1-2

The invitation to "become imitators of God" follows from the description of the "new human that is being created according to God" ([*Eph. 4:24*](#)).

Notice, then, that this link to the new human is directly connected to the model of the Messiah's love, exemplified in the self-giving offering of his life as a sacrifice and offering. This is foundational for Paul's experience and conviction about the Messiah's love.

Galatians 2:20 Instructor's Translation

I have been crucified with the Messiah, and I no longer live, but the Messiah lives in me. And what I now live in the flesh, by faith I live in the Son of God who loved me and gave himself over for me.

Notice also that being an imitator of God requires imitating the love of the Messiah. The two are so closely aligned in Paul's mind that to imitate one is to imitate the other, which was introduced already in Ephesians 4:32, "just as God in the Messiah forgave y'all."

Reflection Question

In Ephesians, Paul teaches that the new humanity is a present reality. Reflect on the idea that Paul is saying "act as you really are" rather than "become somebody different." What difference does this make?